Bhikkhunī Antarāyika Dhammas

Disqualifying principles for Buddhist ordination and their origins

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To the Sangha who have kept Bhikkhuni ordination alive for 2500 years.

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1 Vepurisikā, Dvipuruṣikā

There word *vepurisikā* in the Pali Canon does not appear anywhere other than in the Pali *Bhikkhunikkhandhaka* section on the questons for ordination of a *Bhikkhunī*.

There is a similar word mentioned in the Sanskrit Canon that seems to be closely related and also appears in the same place in the section on the *Bhikkhunī* ordination questions. The word *dvipuruṣikā* appears in the only surviving copy on the *Bhikṣuṇī Vinaya* of the Mahāsāṃghika-Lokottaravāda school[1]. This word does not appear in any other known Sanskrit texts.

The two traditions approach the concept through slightly different semantic angles:

Tradition	**Term**	**Etymology**	**Literal meaning**
Theravāda	*vepurisikā*	*vi-* (anomalous/deviant) + *purisa* (man) + *-ikā* (feminine suffix)	a deviant or anomalous man-woman
Lokottaravāda	*dvipuruṣikā*	*dvi-* (two) + *puruṣa* (man/person) + *-kā* (feminine suffix)	having the nature of two persons

The Theravāda commentary, the *Samantapāsādikā*, glosses this term as: "A woman who has a beard and mustache, and possesses the physical form of a man"[2].

The Lokottaravāda school, unlike the Theravāda school, has no surviving commentarial texts on which we can draw. From the etymological context, it seems to approach this concept as a phenotypic variant—specifically, a female person who has developed secondary male characteristics (such as a beard, mustache, deep voice, and/or heavily masculine frame).

There is only one other known surviving copy of a Sanskrit text that contains the ordination questions for *Bhikkhunīs*, being of the Mūlasarvāstivāda school[3]. Two more copies of the ordination questions for *Bhikkhus* survived of the Sarvāstivāda school[4]. All these three texts do not mention the word *dvipuruṣikā*, but they mention the word *ubhayavyañjanā*, while the text from the Lokottaravāda school lists the *dvipuruṣikā* only.

[1]Roth [1970]. The Chinese pilgrim Faxian, who translated a large number of texts into Chinese, procured his physical Mahāsaṅghika manuscripts at a monastery in Pāṭaliputra. Pāṭaliputra was the historical cradle of the core, ancestral Mahāsaṅghika order. The Lokottaravāda branch branched off and flourished primarily in the northwest, particularly around Bamiyan (modern-day Afghanistan). Although Faxian did walk through northwestern India on his outward journey, he explicitly laments in his travelogue that in Northern and Northwestern India, the Vinaya was taught entirely through oral recitation and memory—there were no physical manuscripts available for him to purchase or copy (Legge [1886] pp. 98–99). When Xuanzang visited the Bamiyan Valley in 643 CE, he collected a lot of the Sanskrit texts of this school and brought them back to China. Unfortunately, all the original Sanskrit texts, mostly written on berch-bark, palmost all the physical Sanskrit manuscripts carried across Central Asia or the maritime Silk Roads by ancient Chinese pilgrims over the centuries.

[2]Sp.1.285

[3]Schmidt [1993]

[4]Härtel [1956] and Chung [2004]

It is also noteworthy in this case that the Theravāda school is the only school that mentions both the *ubhatobyañjanā* and the *vepurisikā*, while all other schools only list one of them. Whenever there is a discrepancy where only one school lists something where the others remain silent, it likely denotes a later addition to the texts.

Considering the close proximity in meaning between the *dvipuruṣikā* and *ubhayavyañjanā*, it might be possible that the same concept is meant. Also the fact that only two schools make any mention of this concept, while all the Chinese translations, of which the Sanskrit originals were lost, do not, warrents a closer look at the Chinese texts.

In Vimala [2021] I traced the Pali term *paṇḍaka* back to ancient Vedic mythology and social-religious ritual classes. This culture was very different from the Chinese and because the Chinese translators did not have an adequate word for this term, they used concepts from their own culture. It would not be surprising if a similar textual confusion has happened with the word *dvipuruṣikā*.

In Chinese Buddhist translations and Abhidharma psychology, two distinct terms are often used when navigating intersex or non-binary physical characteristics. While sometimes used loosely as synonyms, they maintain a strict technical separation:

Term	**Literal meaning**	**Gloss**
二形 (èr xíng)	dual form / signs	Refers to external morphology and secondary sex characteristics.
二根 ((èr gēn)	dual faculties / organs	Refers strictly to anatomy. It requires the concurrent physical presence of both functional sets of genitalia.

Table 1: Bhikkhunī Antarāyika dhammas in Buddhist schools

	Theravāda	Mahīśāsaka	Dharmaguptaka	Sarvāstivāda	Mahāsāṃghika	Mahāsāṃghika-Lokottaravāda	Mūlasarvāstivāda		
	Cullavagga X, Khandhaka 20	T1421	T 1428	T 1435	T 1425	Bhikṣuṇī-vinaya (Roth)	T1453	D0006	BhīKaVā (Schmidt)
English translation†	Pali	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Sanskrit	Chinese	Tibetan	Sanskrit
on genitals									
Do you lack genitals?	1 (nasi animittā)						14 (無道)	19 (mtshan med pa)	17 (mā avyañjanā)
Are your genitals incomplete?	2 (nasi nimittamattā)	8 (女根具足不)		9 (非偏不)			13 (汝非小道)	24 (mtshan ma tsam yod pa)	22 (mā naimittikī)
Are your genitals too small?			11 (道小)	11 (女根不小不)					
Do you have genital prolapse?	7 (nasi sikharaṇī)				25 (非爛墮不)	21 (mā śikhiriṇī)			
Do you have (vaginal) fistula?	10 (nasi sambhinnā)	11 (非二道合不)	10 (二道合)	10 (不二道合不)	26 (非二道通不)		15 (二道合)	21 (gle 'dams pa)	19 (mā saṃbhinnavyañjanā)
Do you have genital hair?				6 (女根上有毛不)					
are your genitals withered or decayed?				7 (不枯壞不)	27 (非破不)				
on menstruation									
Do you menstruate?	3 (nasi alohitā)	12 (月水出不)		16 (非無月忌不)	31 (非無血不)		17 (無血不)	23 (khrag med pa)	21 (mā alohinī)
Do you menstruate continuously?	4 (nasi dhuvalohitā)	13 (不常出不)		15 (非恒有月水不)	30 (非常血病不)		16 (汝非身常流血不)	22 (rtag tu khrag 'dzag pa)	20 (mā sadāprasrutalohinī)
Do you always wear a menstruation pad?	5 (nasi dhuvacoḷā)				32 (非一月常血不)				

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English translation†	Pali	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Sanskrit	Chinese	Tibetan	Sanskrit
Do you have vaginal discharge?				8 (無癰下病不)					
Are you incontinent?	6 (nasi paggharantī)	(漏病 in list of diseases)	12 (大小便常漏)		(不禁 in list of diseases)		(下漏 in list of diseases)		
on third gender									
Are you an itthipaṇḍakā?	8 (nasi itthipaṇḍakā)	9 (汝非黃門不)				23 (mā stripaṇḍikā)	18 (汝非黃門不)		
Are you manlike?	9 (nasi vepurisikā)					22 (mā dvipuruṣikā)			
Are you a ubhatobyañjanā?	11 (nasi ubhatobyañjanā)		9 (二根)					20 (mtshan gnyis pa)	18 (mā ubhayavyañjanā)
on reproduction									
Are you pregnant?								18 (sbrum ma)	16 (mā gurviṇī)
Are you a barren woman?		10 (非石女不)			24 (非石女不)				
Are you incapable (of sexual intercourse)?				5 (非是不能女不)					
Are you impotent?				12 (非是不能產不)	33 (非不能女不)				
Do you lack milk (or breasts)?				13 (非是無乳不)	28 (不無乳不)				
Do you have just one breast?				14 (非是一乳不)	29 (非一乳不)				

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English translation†	Pali	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Sanskrit	Chinese	Tibetan	Sanskrit
on mental state									
Are you vicious?								16 (mi srun pa)	14 (mā caṇḍā)
Are you overcome with grief?							12 (汝非憂愁損心不)	17 (mya ngan gyis gdungs pa)	15 (mā śokahatā)
Are you a man-hater?						24 (mā puruṣadveṣiṇī)			
on being human									
Are you human?	12 (manussāsi)	6 (是人不)		2 (是人不)					
Are you a non-human?				3 (非是非人不)					
Are you a woman?	13 (itthīsi)	7 (是女人不)	8 (是女人不)	1 (汝是女不)	23 (汝是女不)		1 (汝是女人不)	1 (bud med)	1 (strī tvaṃ)
You are a magical apparition?				4 (非畜生不)			31 (非化人不)	11 (sprul pa)	10 (mā vaktavyikā)
on social status									
Are you a slave?	14 (bhujissāsi)	5 (非婢不)	7 (非婢不)	17 (非婢不)	18 (汝非婢不)	15 (mā dāsi)	7 (汝非婢不)	6 (bran mo)	6 (māsi dāsī)
Have you been abducted?				20 (非破得不)	19 (非養女不)			7 (phrogs)	7 (na hi mā āhṛtikā)
Have you been sold?				19 (非買得不)	19 (非養女不)			9 (btsongs pa)	8 (mā vikrītikā)
Are you a pawn?								8 (rnyed pa)	

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English translation†	Pali	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Sanskrit	Chinese	Tibetan	Sanskrit
Have you offered yourself as a servant in lieu of payment of a loan?				18 (非客作不)					9 (mā vaktavyikā)
Are you desired by anyone?								10 (chags pa)	
Are you free from debt?	15 (aṇaṇāsi)	1 (不負債不)	6 (不負人債不)	24 (不負他物不)	20 (不負人債不)	17 (mā ṛṇahārikā)	32 (汝非負債不)	44 (gzhan gyi lon mang yang rung nyung yang rung chags pa)	42 (mā tvayā kasya cit kiñ cid deyaṃ alpaṃ vā prabhūtaṃ vā)
Are you employed by the king?	16 (nasi rājabhaṭī)	4 (不屬官不)		22 (非吏婦不)	21 (非兵婦不)	18 (mā rājabhaṭi)	8 (汝非宮人不) + 9 (國主聽汝不)	12 (rgyal po la gtses pa)	11 (mā rājabhaṭī)
Are you the wife of a soldier?		2 (非他婦不)		21 (非兵婦不)					
Do you bear a grudge against the king?								13 (rgyal po dang 'khon pa)	12 (mā rājakilviṣiṇī)
Have you acted to harm the king (or instigated others to do so)?				23 (非犯官事不)	22 (非陰謀王家不)	19 (mā rājñaḥ kilbiṣakāriṇi)	10 (汝非王家毒害人不)	14-15 (rgyal po la gnod pa'i las byas sam/ pa'am byed du bcug pa)	13 (mā tvayā rājāpathyaṃ karma kṛtaṃ vā kāritaṃ vā)
on permission									
Are your father and mother and your husband alive?					1 (父母夫主在不)		4 (汝父母在不)	4 (pha ma dang khyim thab (rnams) gson pa)	4 (jīvatas te mātāpitarau svāmī vā jīvati)
Do you have permission from your parents and husband?	17 (anuññātāsi mātāpitūhi, sāmikena)	3 (夫主聽不) + 16 (父母聽不)	5 (父母若夫主為聽汝不)		2 (父母夫主聽不)	1 (anujñātāsi anujñāpakehi)	5 (聽汝出家不) + 6 (汝夫主在不)	5 (pha dang ma dang khyo rnams/ khyim thab kyis gnang pa)	5 (anujñātāsi mātāpitṛbhyāṃ svāminā vā)

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Are you twenty years old? (or in case of a married woman living in a household twelve years?)	18 (paripuṇṇavīsati-vassāsi)		3 (年滿二十不)				2 (汝年滿二十未？若曾嫁女者問：汝年滿十四未？)	2 (khyim du/na gnas pa lo bcu gnyis pa'am | gzhon nu ma lo nyi shu tshang pa)	2 (strī gṛhoṣitā dvādaśavarṣā kumārikā vā paripūrṇaviṃśativarṣā)
Do you have a full set of bowl and robes?	19 (paripuṇṇaṁ te pattacīvaraṁ)		4 (衣鉢具不)		4 (五衣鉢具不)	3 (paripūrṇan te pātracivaraṃ)	3 (汝五衣鉢具不)	3 (chos gos lnga dang lhung bzed du ldan pa)	3 (paripūrṇaṃ te pañcacīvaraṃ pātraṃ ca)
What's your name?	20 (kiṁnāmāsi)		1 (汝字何等)		7 (汝字何等)		34 (汝名字何)	45 (khyod kyi ming ci)	43 (kinnāmikā tvaṃ)
Has a preceptor been found?		15 (已求和尚未)			3 (求和上尼未)	2 (yācitā te upādhyāyinī)			
What's the name of your preceptor?	21 (kānāmā te pavattinī)		2 (和尚字誰)		8 (和上尼字誰)		35 (鄔波馱耶字何)	46 (khyod kyi mkhan mo'i ming ci)	44 (kinnāmikā te upādhyāyikā)
ānantariya									
Have you killed your father?					9 (汝不殺父母不)	8 (mā pitṛghātini)	20 (汝非殺父不)	26 (pha bsad pa)	25 (mā pitṛghātikā)
Have you killed your mother?					9 (汝不殺父母不)	7 (mā mātṛghātini)	21 (汝非殺母不)	27 (ma bsad pa)	24 (mā mātṛghātikā)
Have you killed an arhat?					10 (不殺阿羅漢不)	9 (mā arhantaghātinī)	22 (汝非殺阿羅漢不)	28 (dgra bcom pa bsad pa)	26 (mā arhadghātikā)
Have you caused a schism in the Sangha?					11 (不破僧不)	10 (mā saṃghabhedikā)	23 (汝非破和合僧伽不)		

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English translation†	Pali	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Sanskrit	Chinese	Tibetan	Sanskrit
Have you shed the blood of a tathāgata with malicious intent?					12 (不惡心出佛身血不佛久已涅槃而故依舊文)	11 (mā tathāgatasya duṣṭacittarudhirot-pādikā)	24 (汝非惡心出佛身血不)	29 (de bzhin gshegs pa'i sku la ngan sems kyis khrag phyung ba)	27 (mā tathāgatasyāntike duṣṭacittarudhirot-pādikā)
other disqualified persons									
Have you seduced a bhikṣu?					13 (不壞比丘淨戒不)	12 (mā bhikṣudūṣikā)	19 (汝非污苾芻不)	25 (dge slong bslus pa)	23 (mā bhikṣudūṣikā)
Are you an adherent of a non-Buddhist sect?						13 (mā stainyasamvāsikā)	25 (汝非外道不)	30 (mu stegs can)	28 (mā tīrthikā)
Have you gone over to a non-Buddhist sect?					15 (非越濟人不)	14 (mā tirthikā-pakrāntikā)	26 (現是外道汝非趣外道不)	31 (mu stegs can du 'gro ba)	29 (mā tīrthāvakrāntikā)
Have you previously ordained, gone over to a non-Buddhist sect and now returned again?							27 (先已出家，還歸外道，更復重來汝非賊住不)		
Are you not a notorious bandit?					14 (非賊盜住不)	16 (mā avapitikā)	11 (汝非賊不)	32 (rkun po'i rgyal mtshan can)	30 (mā caurī)
You are not one who lives by theft, are you?								33 (rkun gnas pa / rku thabs su gnas pa)	31 (mā dhvajabaddhikā / mā steyasaṃvāsikā)
Do you live apart?							28 (汝非別住不)	34 (so sor gnas pa)	32 (mā nānāsaṃvāsikā)
Are you entitled to live [with the order]?							29 (汝非不共住不)	35 (mi gnas pa)	33 (mā asaṃvāsikā)

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on going forth									
Did you renounce the household life voluntarily?					16 (不自出家不)				
Have you received the full ordination previously?					17 (本曾受具足不)	20 (upasampannapūrvāsi)	33 (汝非先出家不)	36 (sngon rab tu byung ba)	34 (kaccit tvaṃ pūrvaṃ pravrajiteti)
Have you now gone forth and practiced chastity well?							30 (先犯重人汝不)	37 (da ltar rab tu byung nas tshangs par spyod pa yang dag par spyad pa)	35 (kaccit tvayā samyag brahmacaryañ caritaṃ)
Have you requested the two years' training in the six dharmas and the six subordinate dharmas from the bhikṣuṇī saṃgha?								38 (dge slong ma' i dge 'dun gyis lo gnyis su chos drug dang rjes su chos drug bslab pa gsol pa (second list: byin pa))	36 (kaccit tvayā bhikṣuṇīsaṃghe dve varṣe ṣaṭsu dharmeṣu ṣaṭsv anudharmeṣu śikṣā yācitā)
Have you trained for two years in the six dharmas and the six subordinate dharmas?		14 (學二歲戒日滿不)			5 (學戒二歲滿不)	4 (deśitaśikṣāsi)		39 (lo gnyis su chos drug dang rjes su chos drug gi bslab pa bslabs pa)	37 (śikṣitā tvaṃ dve varṣe ṣaṭsu dharmeṣu ṣaṭsv anudharmeṣu śikṣāyāṃ)
Do you wish to receive the full ordination?		17 (欲受具足戒不)							
Are you perfected in the training?						5 (paripūrṇaśikṣāsi)			

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English translation†	Pali	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Chinese	Sanskrit	Chinese	Tibetan	Sanskrit
Has the saṅgha of bhikṣuṇīs conferred the vow that generates the holy life?								40 (dge slong ma'i dge 'dun gyis tshangs par spyad pa skyed pa'i sdom pa phog gam)	38 (dattā te bhikṣuṇīsaṃghena brahmacaryopasthā-nasaṃvṛtir dattā)
Have the saṅgha of bhikṣuṇīs performed the preliminary formal acts?					6 (作畜眾羯磨未)			41 (dge slong ma'i dge 'dun gyis sngar bya ba'i las rnams byas pa)	39 (kṛtaṃ te bhikṣuṇīsaṃghena pūrvakālakaraṇīyaṃ kṛtaṃ)
Have you been approved by the bhikṣuṇīs and are their minds pleased?						6 (sammatāsi viśuddhāsi bhikṣuṇīhi)		42 (dge slong ma'i dge 'dun rnams kyi sems mgu bar byas pa)	40 (ārādhitaṃ te bhikṣuṇīsaṃghasya / cittam ārādhitaṃ)
Are you completely pure?						6 (sammatāsi viśuddhāsi bhikṣuṇīhi)		43 (bar chad kyi chos rnams las yongs su dag pa)	41 (pariśuddhāsi na vā)

† I use the positive formulated form in this table after Brahmali [2021] (pp. 547ff). Bhikkhu Brahmali uses a formulation like: "Are you ... ?" while Carola Roloff [2020] (pp. 211–216) uses the formulation: "You are not ..., are you?". Although the latter formulation is more precise, I have choses to use the more concise translation for ease of reading.

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